This hearty, substantial soup improves with reheating, so it benefits from being made a day in advance. Reheat gently over low heat.

tuscan bean soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 1 HR 20 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

4 tbsp extra virgin olive oil, plus extra for drizzling
1 onion, chopped
2 carrots, sliced
1 leek, sliced
2 garlic cloves, chopped
1 x 14oz (400g) can chopped tomatoes
1 tbsp tomato purée
1 quart (1 liter) chicken stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 x 14oz (400g) can borlotti beans, navy beans, or cannellini beans, drained and rinsed
9oz (250g) baby spinach leaves or spring greens, shredded
8 slices ciabatta bread
grated Parmesan cheese, for sprinkling

1 Heat the oil in a large saucepan and cook the onion, carrot, and leek over low heat for 10 minutes, or until softened but not colored. Add the garlic and cook for 1 minute. Add the tomatoes, tomato purée, and stock. Season to taste with salt and pepper.

2 Mash half the beans with a fork and add to the pan. Bring to a boil, then lower the heat and simmer for 30 minutes. Add the remaining beans and spinach to the pan. Simmer for another 30 minutes.

3 Toast the bread until golden, place 2 pieces in each soup bowl, and drizzle with olive oil. To serve, spoon the soup into the bowls, top with a sprinkling of Parmesan, and drizzle with a little more olive oil.